

The Best Places to Eat Ceviche

La Mar (moderate)

Part of the expanding empire of restaurants run by Peru's culinary ambassador and cordon-bleu-trained chef Gastón Acurio, La Mar is a lunch-only, seafood-focused destination, a *cebicheria peruano* (Peruvian *ceviche* restaurant). The restaurant doesn't take reservations and the best way to secure a table is to arrive around noon, otherwise you're likely to have a lengthy wait at the bar. Not that this is a bad thing, as they produce a great version of the pisco sour cocktail – fluffy, icy, and just a little bit addictive – as well as tempting snacks while you wait. There's a whole list of *ceviche* on the menu, from *clásico* with hot chili pepper, tiger's milk, and fresh fish, to *tumbes* – black scallops from the north of Peru, with octopus, mussels, calamari, and clams. Try the *degustación*: a selection of five *ceviche* to share, including *clásico*, *tumbes*, *nikei* (tuna), *elegante* (mixed fish), and *mistura* (shellfish, salmon, and fiercely hot green *rocoto* chili). There's also *tiradito*, which is like a cross between carpaccio and sashimi: paper-fine slices of raw fish dressed with lime and chili pepper.

Avenida La Mar 770, Miraflores, Lima;
open noon–5 PM Mon–Thu, noon–5:30 PM Fri,
11:45 AM–5:30 PM Sat–Sun;
www.lamarcebicheria.com

Also in Lima

Just down the road from La Mar, **Pescados Capitales** (www.pescadoscapitales.com; *moderate*) is another lunch-only seafood destination. The name is a pun on *pescados* (fish) and *pecados* (sins) and the menu plays up the “deadly fins” theme: *ceviche* comes under the heading *pecado original* (original sin), while main courses carry names such as “vanity,” “envy,” and “infidelity.” *Ceviche* at the restaurant features *lenguado* (sole), octopus, mixed fish and shellfish, and deep-sea cachema fish.

Also in Peru

The improbably named **Big Ben** (www.bigbenhuanchaco.com; *inexpensive*) is the oldest restaurant in the beach resort-fishing village of Huanchaco on Peru's northern coast. Pick a table on the umbrella-covered terrace upstairs with a view over the ocean and order a fresh-off-the-boat *ceviche*.

Around the World

Not content with conquering Mexico, Chile, Brazil, Panama, Colombia, and Peru, chef Gastón Acurio has opened a **La Mar** (www.lamarcebicheria.com; *expensive*) in San Francisco. Located at the Embarcadero waterfront, it serves up *ceviche* with a local flavor: mahi-mahi, calamari, and octopus with cilantro and yellow chili pepper marinade; Californian halibut in a classic marinade; and ahi tuna with Japanese cucumber, daikon, and avocado in tamarind-flavored tiger's milk.



Above The Parque del Amor in Miraflores is lined with long, undulating mosaic benches covered in quotes from Peruvian poets

Left The fresh white fish meat of *ceviche* is “cooked” by being steeped briefly in a marinade of lime juice and chili peppers